



Power BI: Building Dashboards

The Consultant's Playbook for Executive Snapshots

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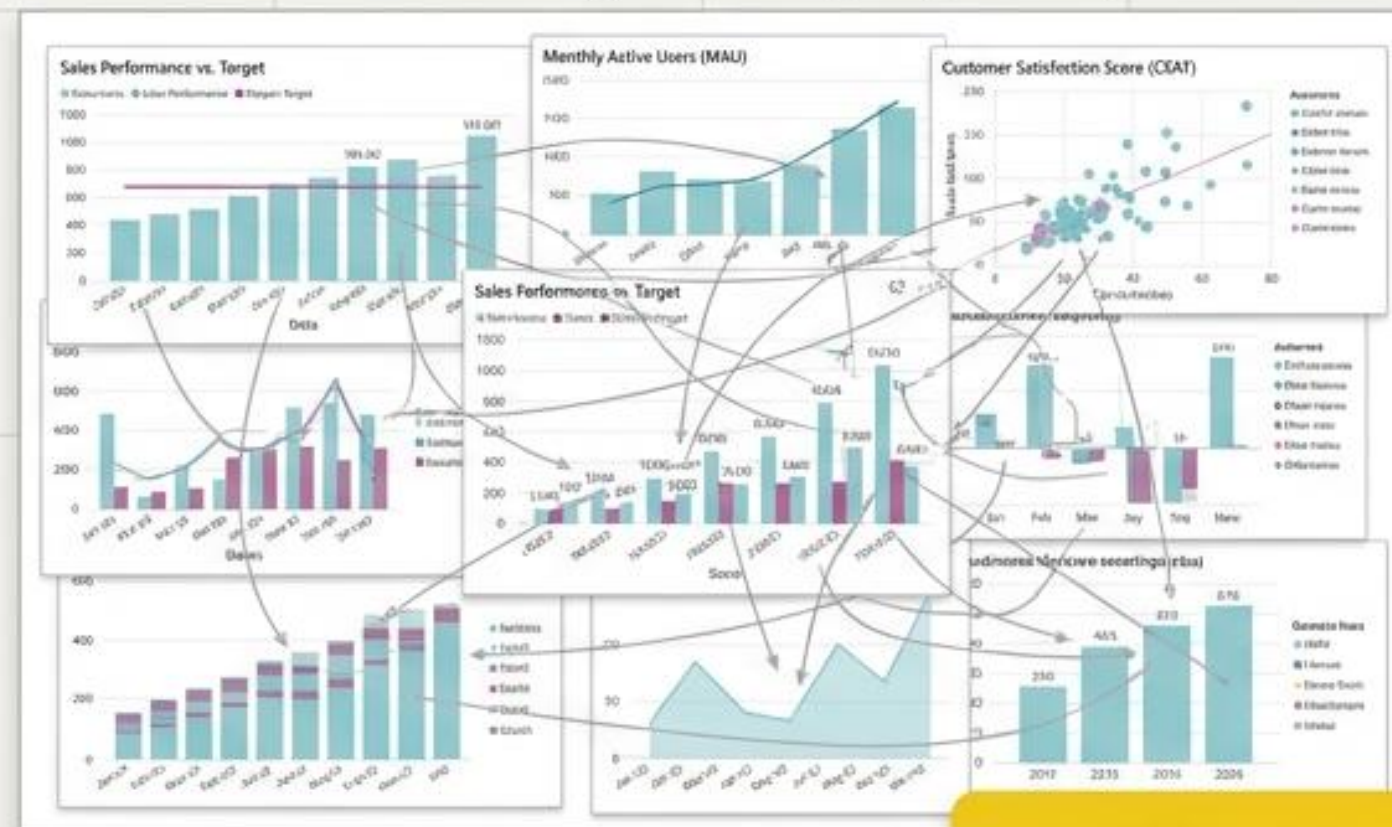
The Great Misunderstanding

Invariably, users say they want to build dashboards.

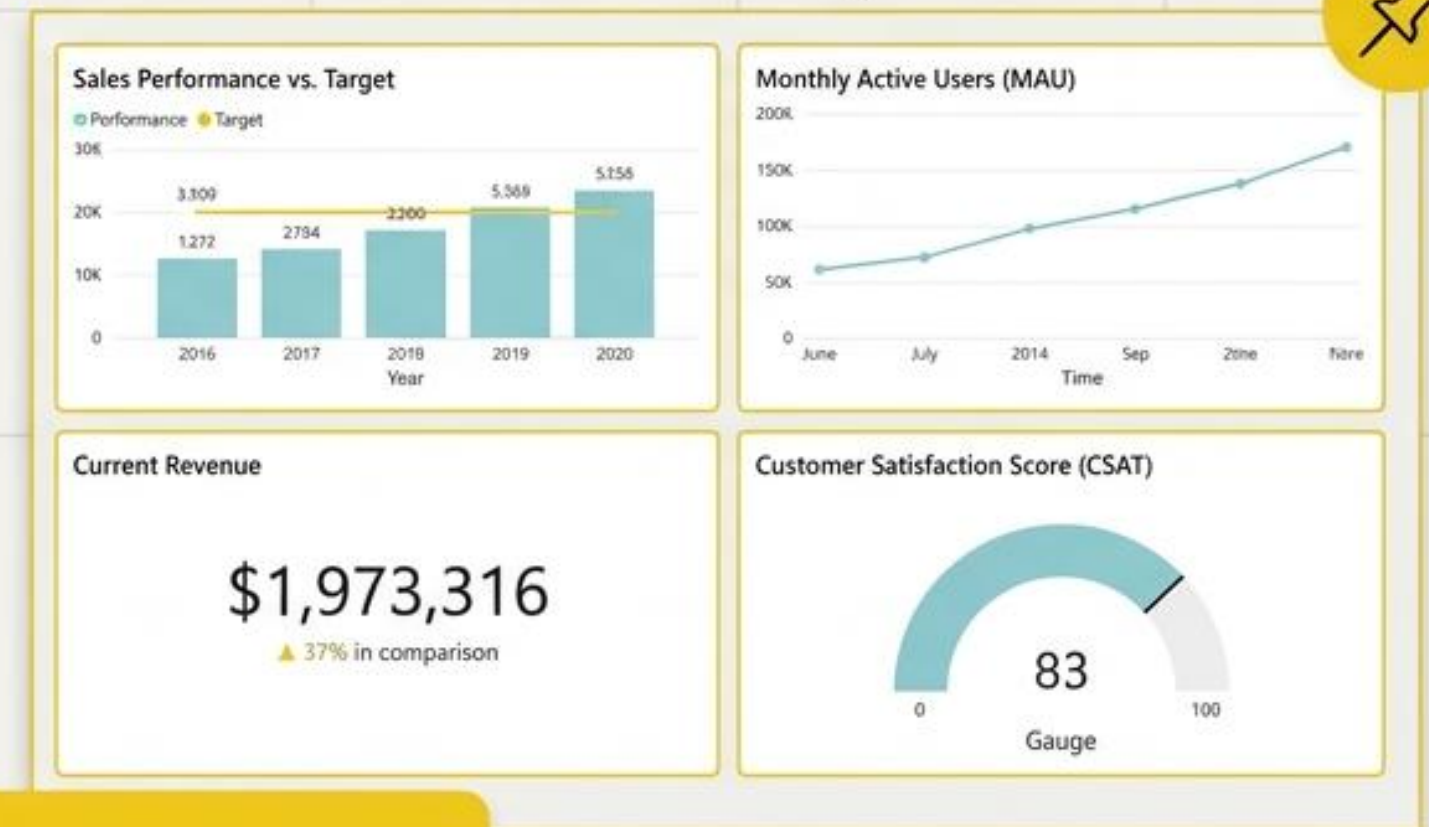
Dig a little deeper, and it turns out they actually want reports.

Dashboards and reports are entirely different analytical tools with different purposes.

What users usually build (Reports)



What a dashboard actually is



A dashboard is a virtual one-page document.
It is a snapshot, not an investigation.



The Diagnostic Matrix: Reports vs. Dashboards

	Reports	Dashboards
Environment	Desktop & Service	Service Only
Data Sourcing	Single Dataset	Visuals from Multiple Datasets/Reports
Default Interactivity	Visuals cross-filter and interact	Static visual tiles; no default interaction
Content Types	Static or refreshed data only	Supports live/streaming content & video
Primary Purpose	Deep, interactive investigation	High-level information snapshot



Designed for the Wall-Mounted Monitor

The perfect application for a dashboard is common-area display. Because these monitors are mounted high on walls, no one expects to interact with them.



The data is displayed for information, not investigation. Setting this expectation early prevents user frustration when tiles don't cross-filter like reports do.



The Curation Engine

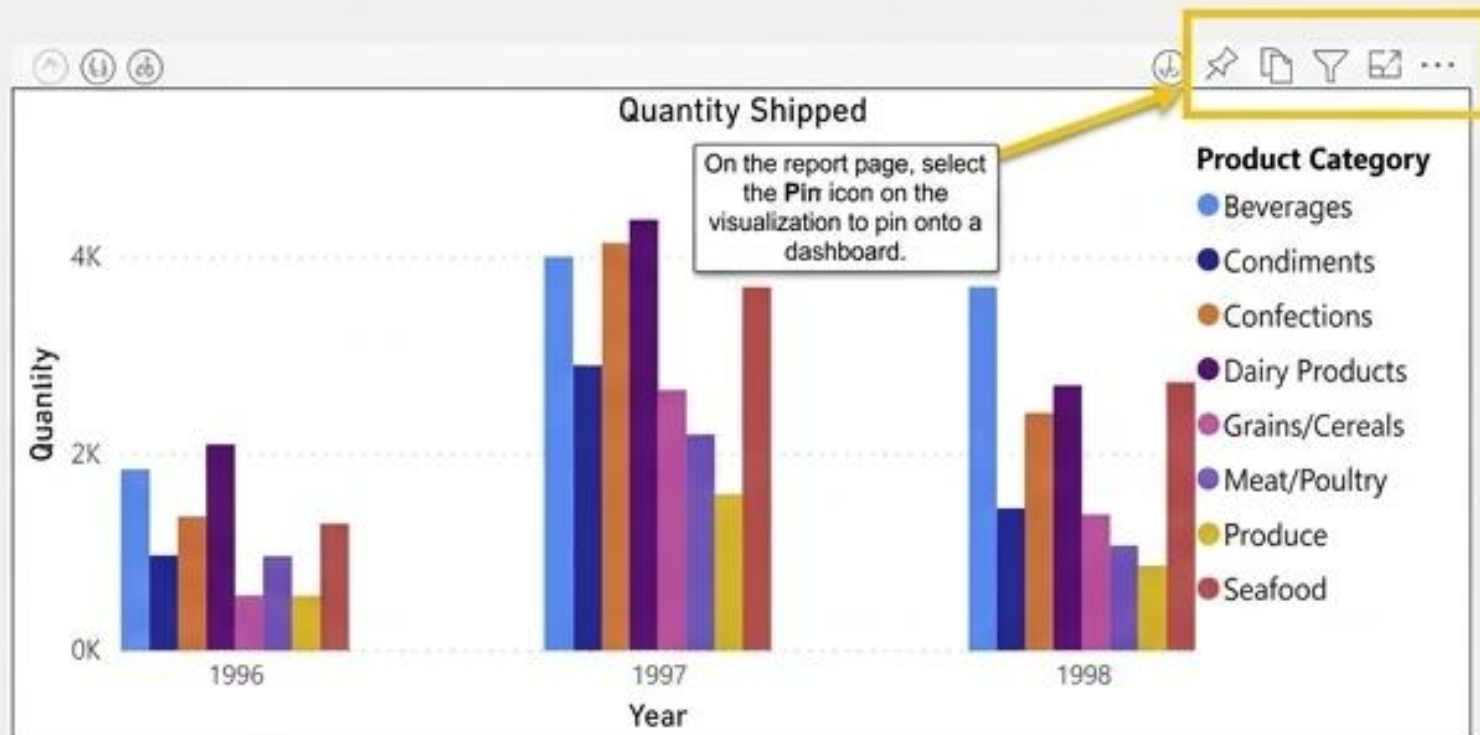
Dashboards act as a curation layer. They extract the most vital metrics from multiple distinct reports and datasets, unifying them into a single pane of glass.



Assembling the Command Center

Step 1: Locate the Pushpin.

Starting from any published report, hover over the target visualization to reveal the header and click the pin icon.



Step 2: Assign the Destination.

Choose to append the tile to an existing dashboard or spin up a new virtual document.

Pin to dashboard [X]

Select an existing dashboard or create a new one.

Where would you like to pin to?

☒ Existing dashboard
☐ New dashboard

Select existing dashboard
Sample Dashboard [v]

[Pin] [Cancel]



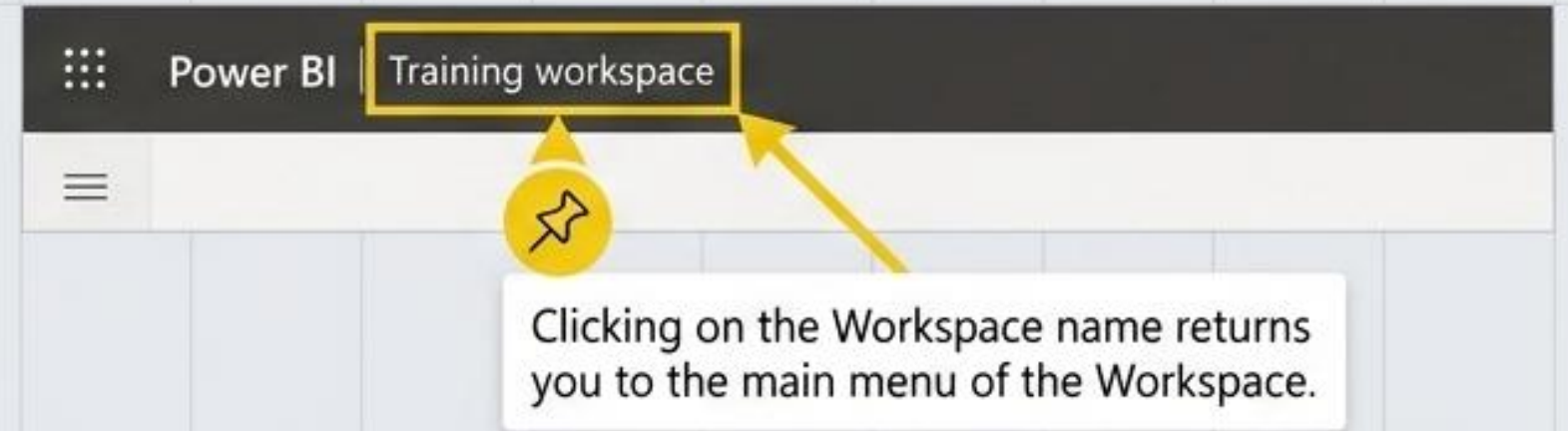
Pro-Tip: Keep scrolling to a minimum by strictly limiting the number of pinned visualizations.

Locating Your Virtual Document

Upper Block

Path A: The Breadcrumb Trail

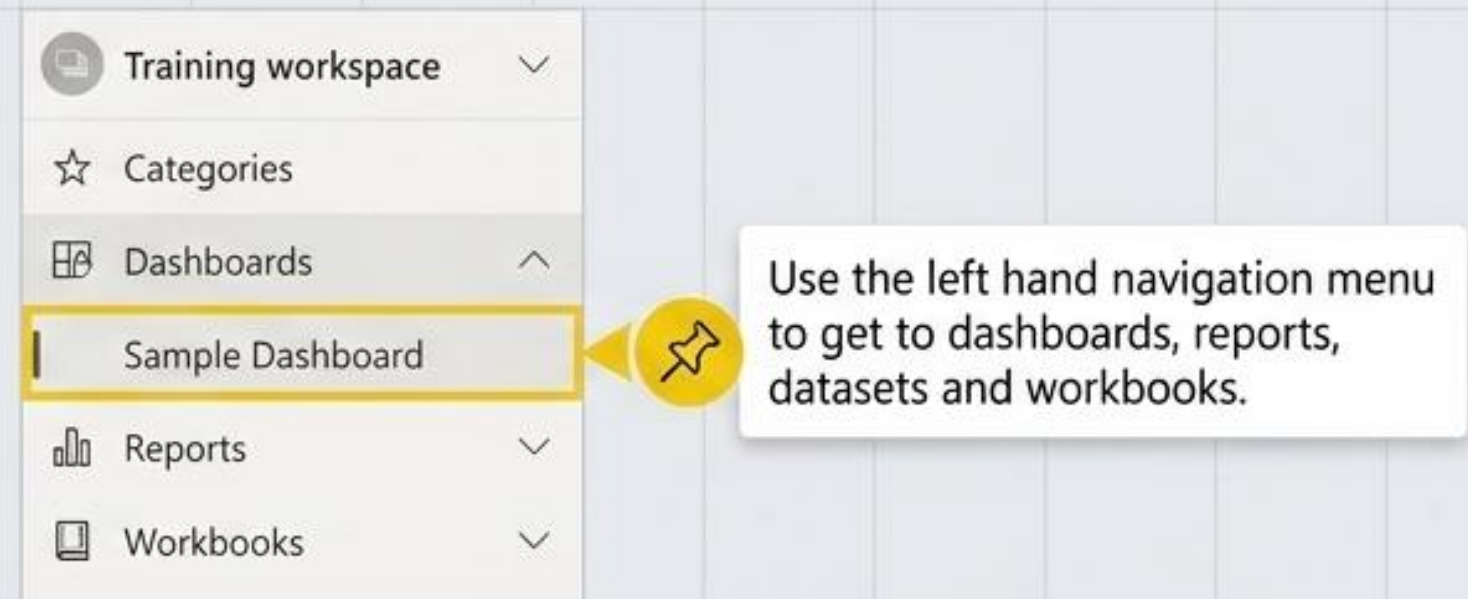
Clicking the Workspace name at the top of the screen returns you to the main directory.



Lower Block

Path B: The Left-Hand Hub

Use the persistent left-side navigation pane to quickly filter content by type (Dashboards, Reports, Workbooks).



Aesthetics and Live Media

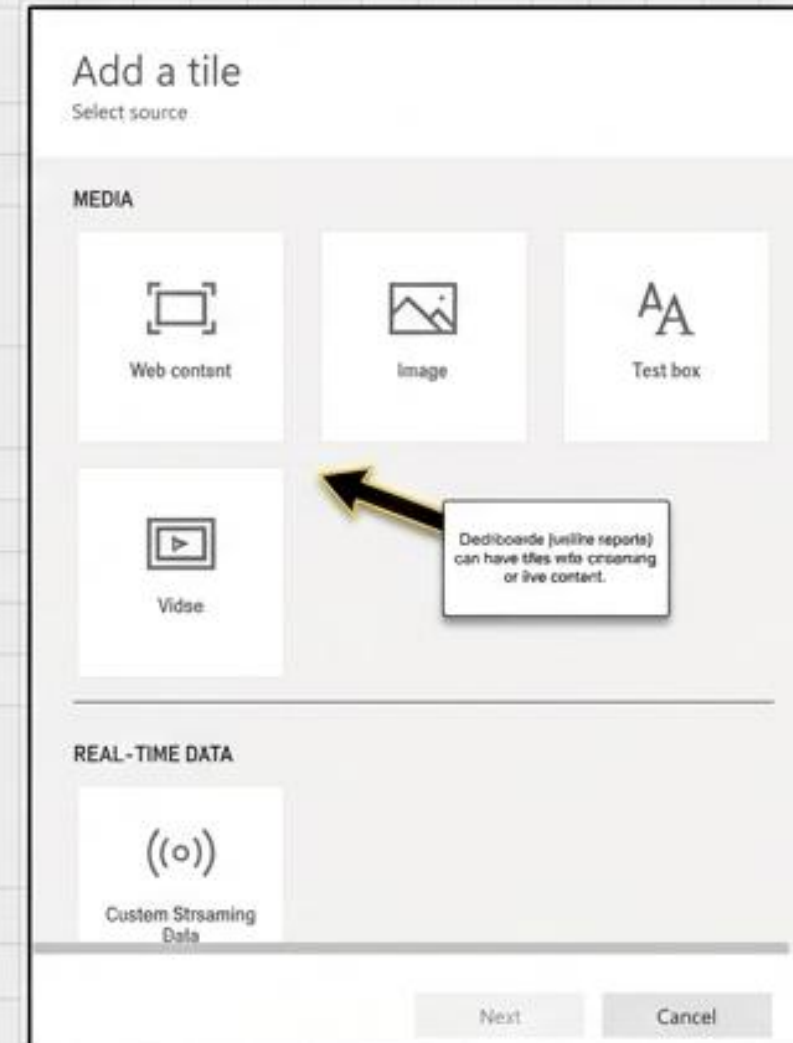
Formatting

Native creative options for dashboards are limited to global themes. For precise control, upload a custom JSON theme file.



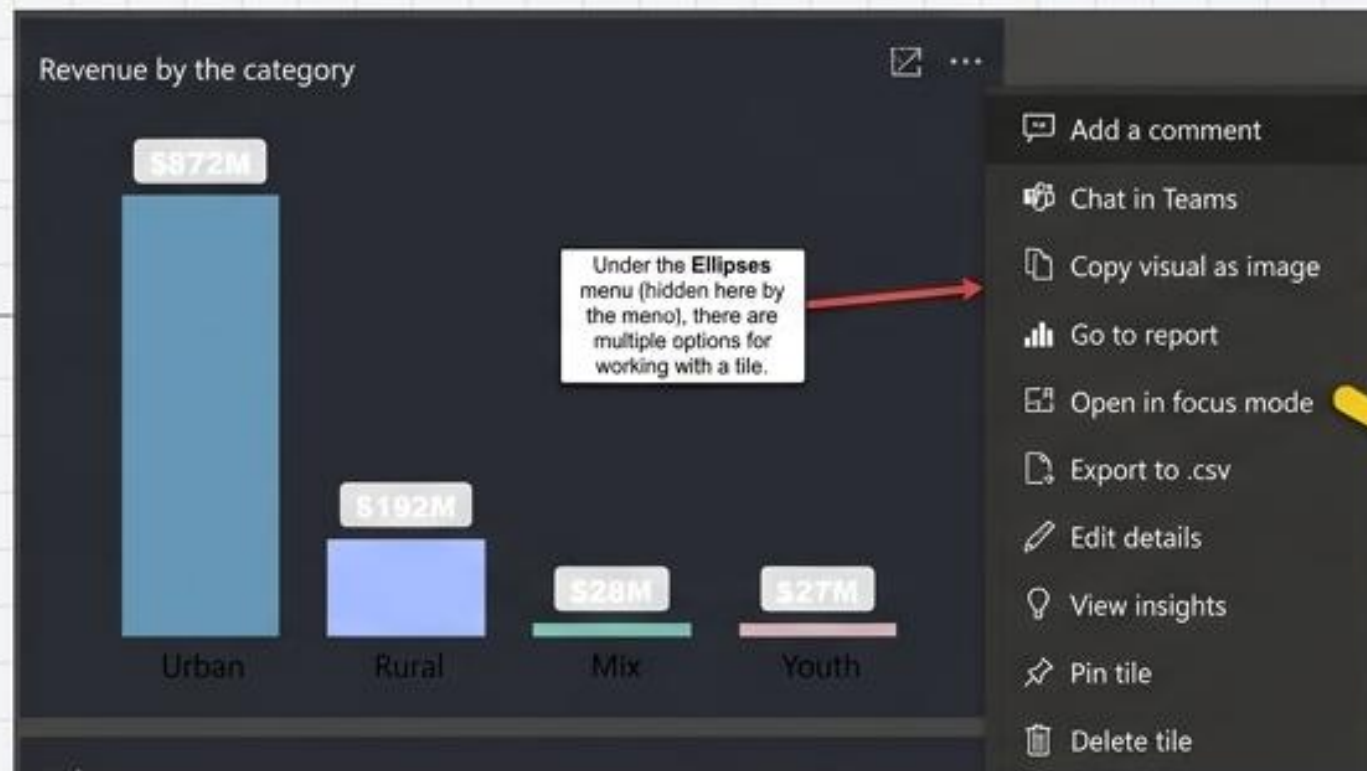
Live Media

Unlike standard reports, dashboards natively support live integration. Use the 'Add a tile' menu to inject web content, video, or real-time data.



Anatomy of a Pinned Tile

Once on a dashboard, visualizations become “tiles”. Editing the visual requires returning to the source report, but the tile wrapper offers specific extraction tools.



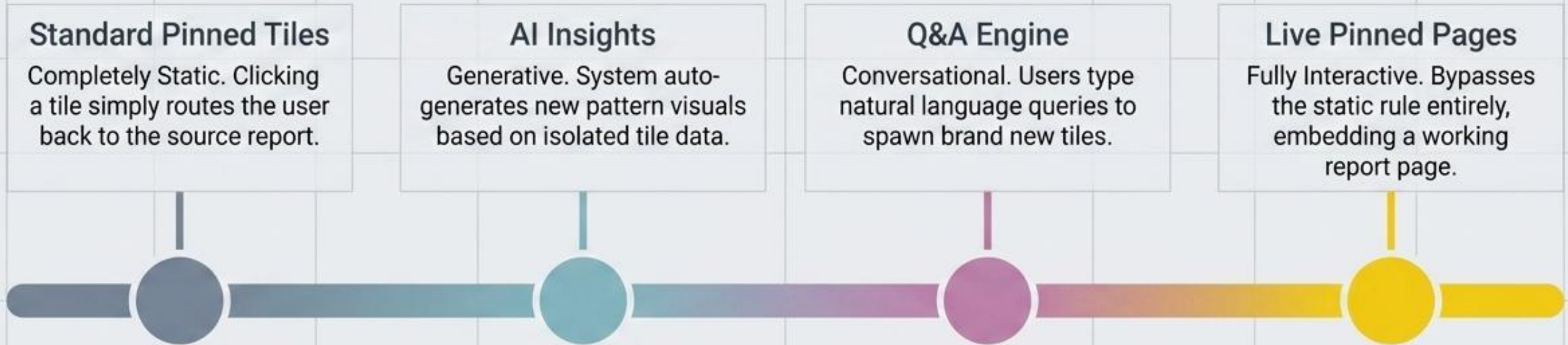
Data Extraction:
Dashboards do not offer a 'view data as table' UI; extraction routes straight to raw CSV files.

The result of **Export to .csv** from a tile on a dashboard.

	A	B	C	D
1	Category	Subcategory	Product Na	Total Sales
2	Urban	Extreme	UE-05	\$36,357,215.21
3	Urban	Extreme	UE-14	\$26,732,898.83
4	Urban	Extreme	UE-15	\$26,324,353.44
5	Urban	Moderatio	UM-01	\$24,436,365.24
6	Urban	Moderatio	UM-80	\$20,583,102.23
7	Urban	Extreme	UE-24	\$20,553,430.24
8	Urban	Extreme	UE-06	\$20,523,430.09
9	Urban	Moderatio	UM-10	\$14,346,870.09
10	Urban	Extreme	UE-16	\$13,896,256.76
11	Urban	Extreme	UE-23	\$12,821,874.61
11	Urban	Extreme	UE-23	\$12,471,874.61
12	Urban	Extreme	UE-09	\$12,475,102.97
13	Urban	Extreme	UE-22	\$12,366,658.88
14	Urban	Extreme	UE-18	\$12,198,982.16
15	Urban	Extreme	UE-01	\$12,170,224.92
16	Urban	Extreme	UE-10	\$11,965,840.79
17	Urban	Extreme	UE-13	\$11,750,840.49
18	Urban	Extreme	UE-13	\$11,730,028.49
19	Urban	Extreme	UE-17	\$11,544,416.68

The Interactivity Spectrum

Dashboards are static snapshots by default. However, you can progressively unlock interactivity using specific Power BI features.



Augmentation via AI Insights



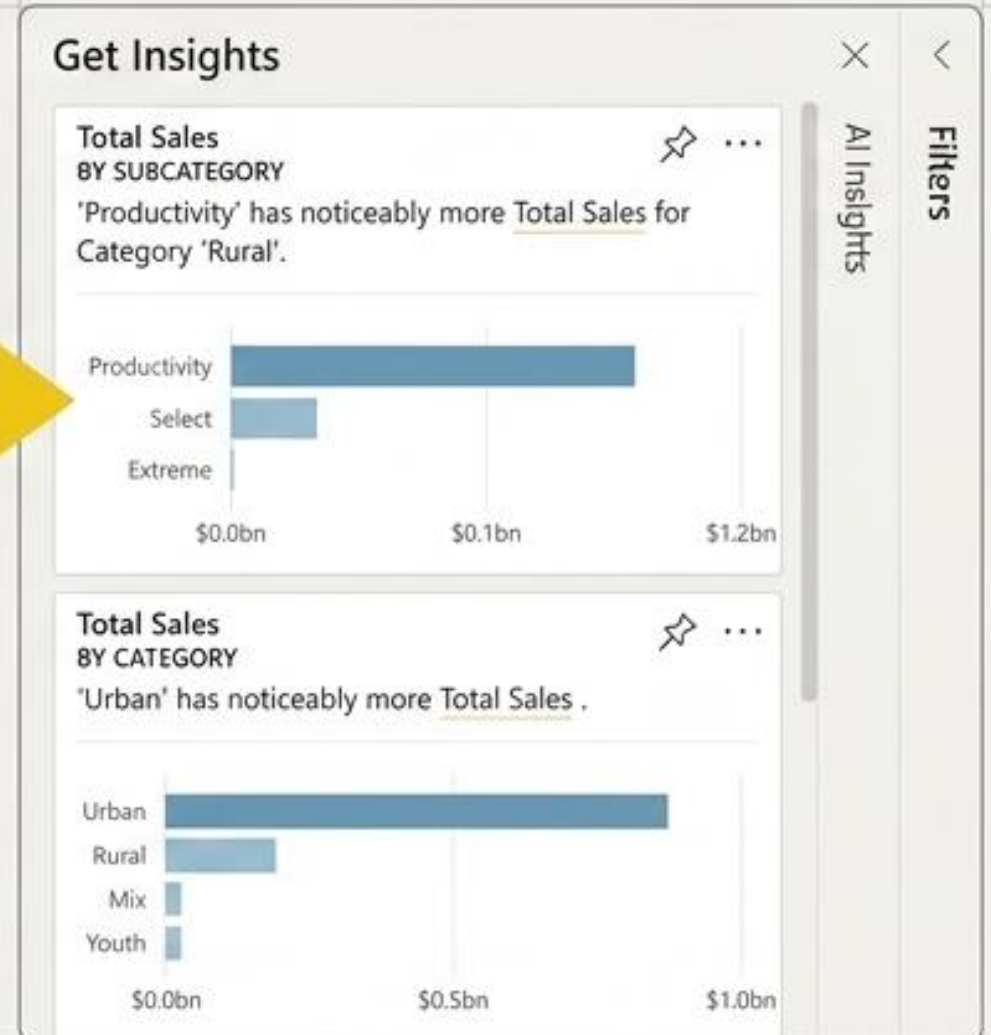
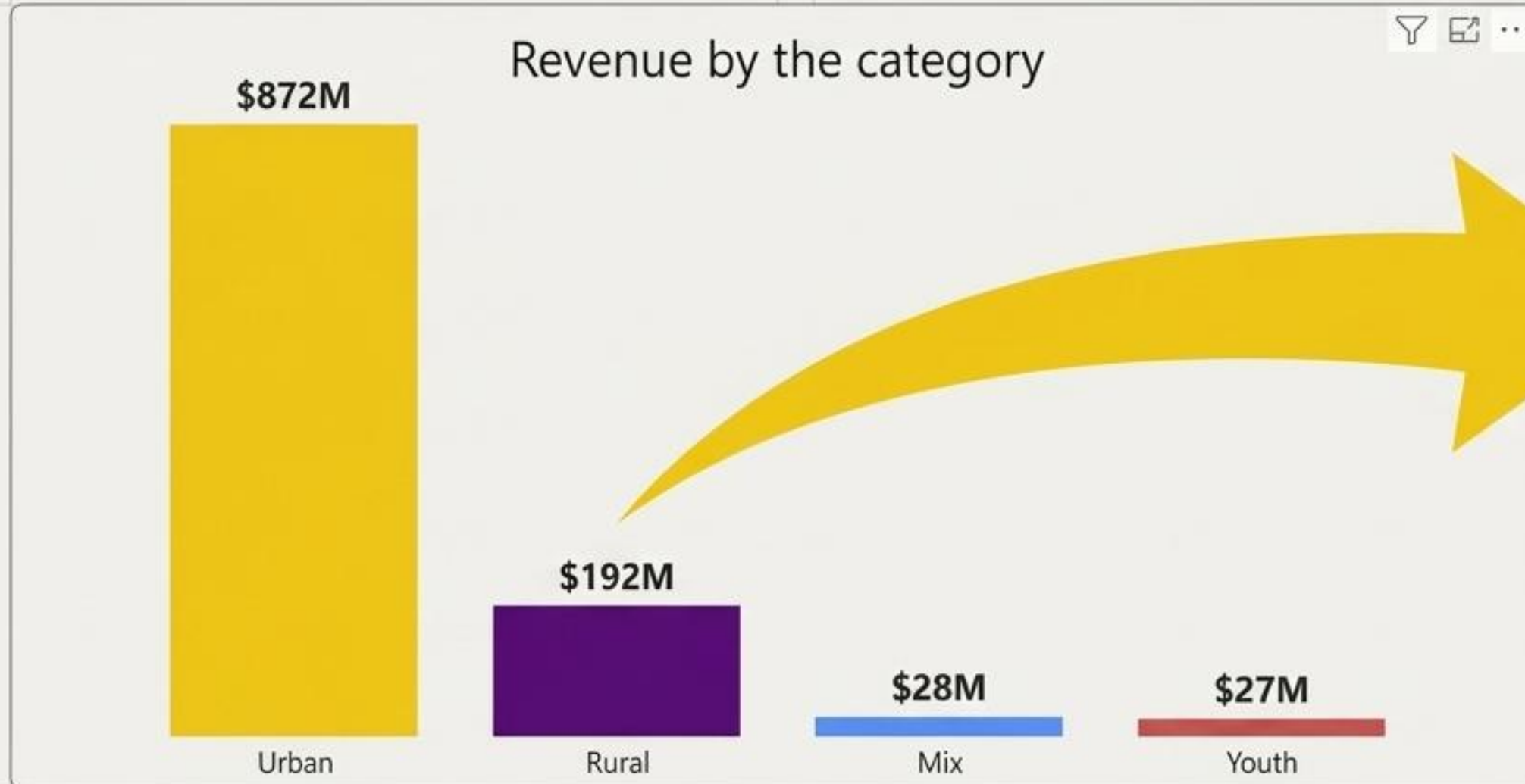
Mechanism: Select "View insights" from any tile's menu.



Result: Power BI's underlying AI scans the data bound to that specific tile to surface hidden relationships.



Action: Valuable new perspectives can be immediately pinned to the dashboard as new tiles.



The Two-Tier Q&A Pipeline

Tier 1: Preparation

Power BI Desktop.

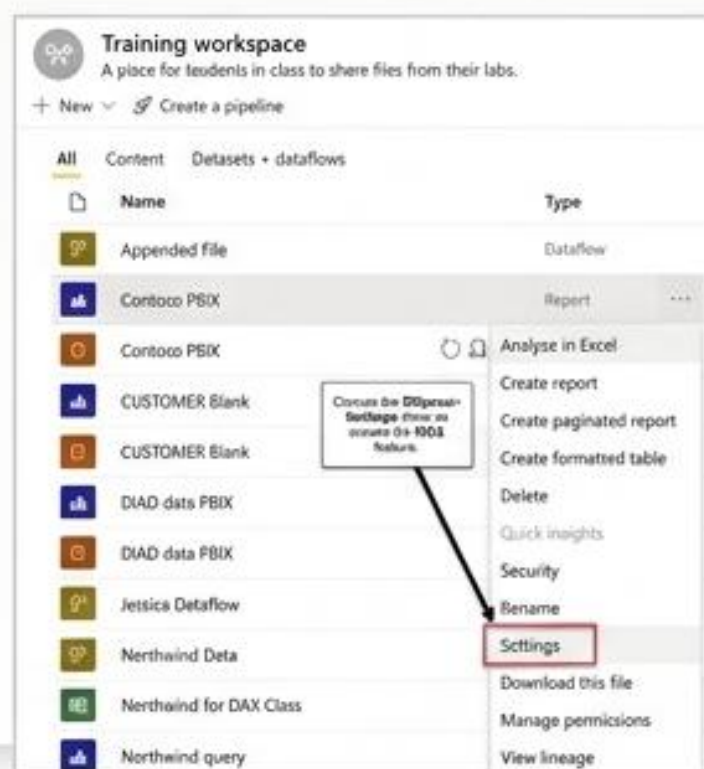
Navigate to Modeling > Q&A Setup before publishing to define synonyms.



Tier 2: Activation

Power BI Service.

Navigate to the underlying Dataset's Settings menu to explicitly toggle Q&A on.



Tier 3: Execution

Dashboard.

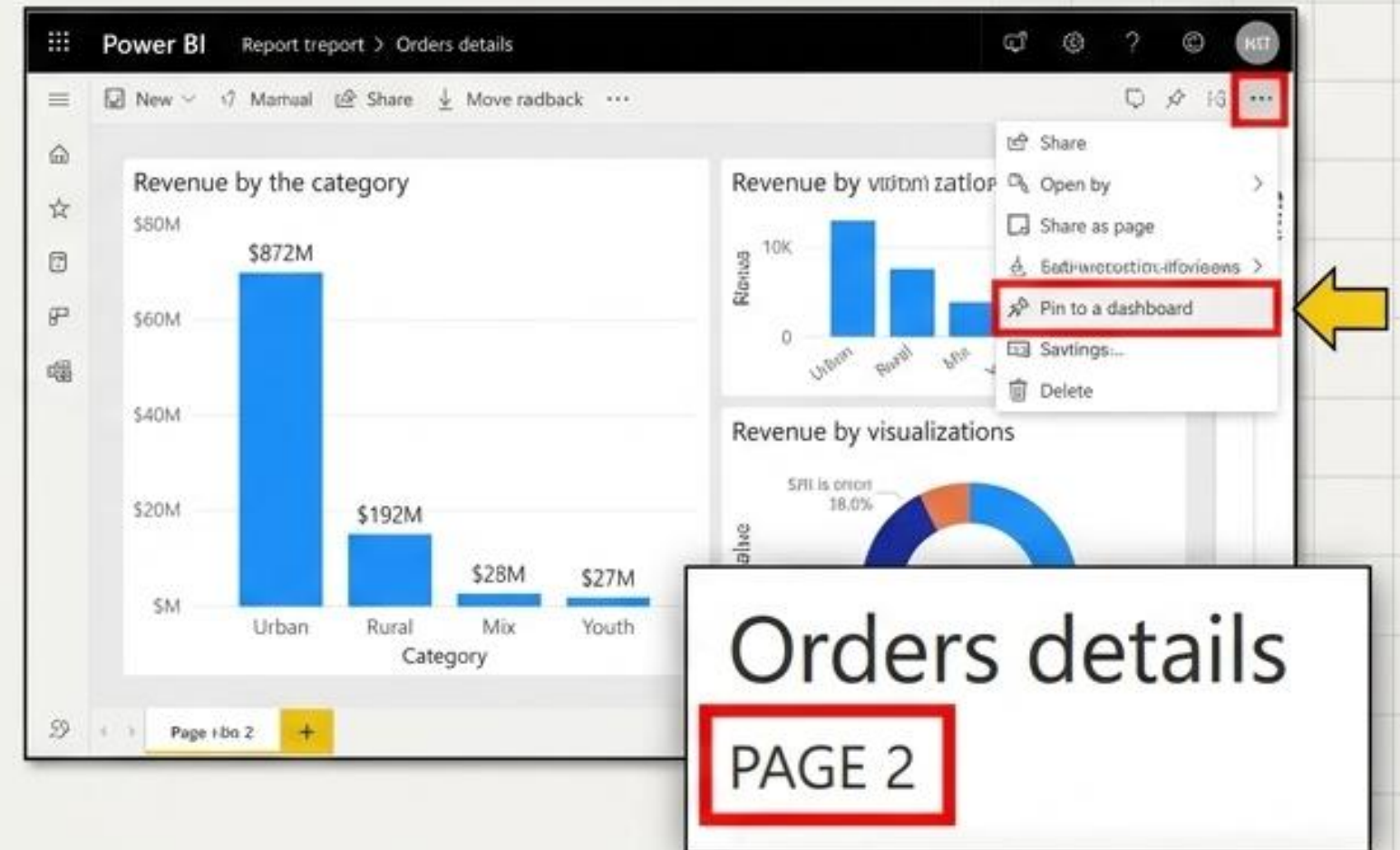
Users ask natural language questions to instantly generate pinnable visuals.



The Rule-Breaker: Pinning Live Pages

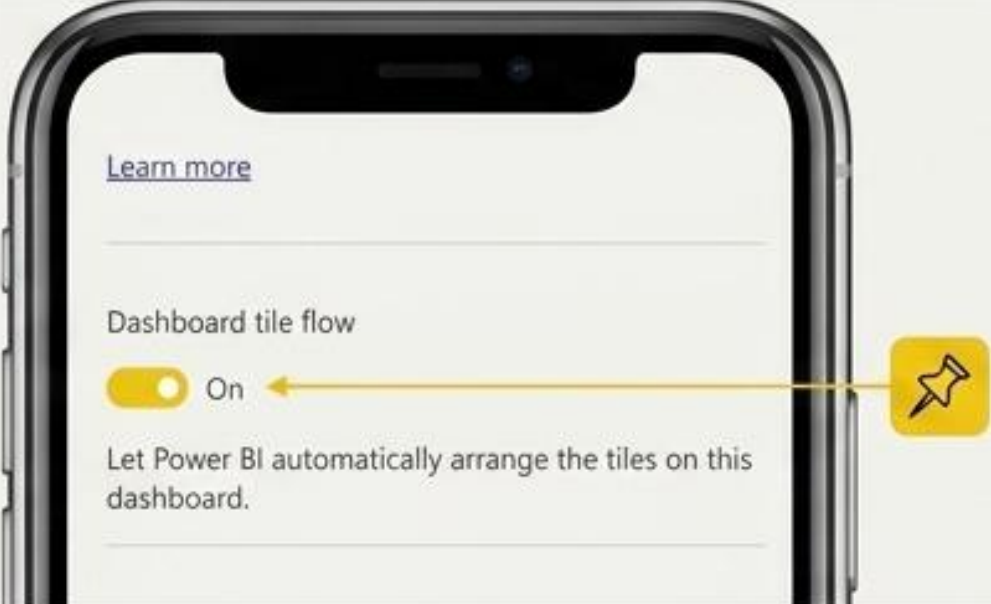
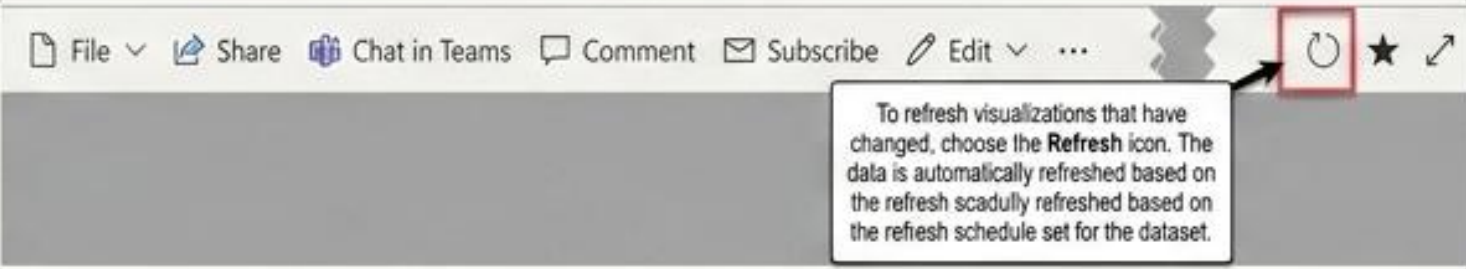
 **The Exception:** If you must have tiles interact with each other on a dashboard, you can pin an entire report page from Read mode.

 **Identification:** Live pages are tagged with the Report Title and Page Number in the upper left corner.



The Consultant's Warning: Think carefully before doing this. If users need full interactivity, they usually just need the source report or a published App. **Do not use dashboards as a substitute for reports.**

Maintenance and Optimization

Tile Flow & Mobile	Data Refresh
	
■ Mobile Views: Unpin tiles safely in Mobile Layout to streamline the phone experience without affecting the desktop view. ■ Tile Flow Architecture: Force Power BI to automatically arrange the grid when tiles are added or removed.	■ Data Refresh: Visuals auto-update based on the underlying dataset's schedule. Use the manual Refresh icon only to pull in structural changes made to the source visuals.



THE GOLDEN RULE OF DASHBOARDS

Information. Not Investigation.

Curate ruthlessly. Pin purposefully. Build command centers, not filing cabinets.